

IQOO Z7 5G

Playing it safe

After flagships and mid-range devices like the iQOO 11 and the iQOO Neo 7, iQOO has come up with its first sub-Rs 20,000 smartphone for 2023, the iQOO Z7 5G. So let's find out if this is worth the Rs 17,499 asking price, or does the latest from iQOO fall behind the competition in terms of value-for-money?

DESIGN

The smartphone borrows a lot from its predecessor, the iQOO Z6 5G. At the back, we get a polycarbonate panel, which has a gradient-like finish and a matte-like feel to the touch. One thing to note here is that the iQOO Z7 5G is a super lightweight smartphone, weighing a mere 175 grams, as against the company's claim of 173 grams. Further, the quality of polycarbonate used is also pretty decent, so the in-hand feel is also good. The size of the iQOO Z7 5G is also average - not too big or too small, a size pretty good for single-handed usage, and the iQOO Z7 5G can easily fit in any pocket.

DISPLAY

The iQOO Z7 5G has a display with good colour accuracy. It's an AMOLED display, so the blacks are deep, the reds are vibrant, and the details are sharp. The phone also supports HDR content. The display is 90Hz, so it is responsive, but there are smartphones in this range that offer a 120Hz refresh rate, so this isn't the most responsive in this segment. This display felt slow after using the likes of Redmi Note 12 and the Realme 10 Pro. We tested the brightness using a Lux Meter, and the smartphone showed a highest of 750 nits of brightness on a blank white screen. The minimum brightness on a white screen, according to our test, came out to be 6 nits.

PERFORMANCE

Performance is iQOO's strongpoint. In most benchmark tests, the smartphone showed better results than most

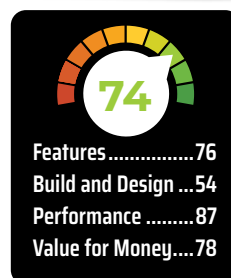
competitors, barring the Motorola Moto G73. On AnTuTu, it scored the highest among all the under Rs 20,000 smartphones launched in 2023, with a score of 479,779. On other CPU-based benchmarks like Geekbench, PCMark and Mobile XPRT3, the phone showed very good numbers, but fell short as compared to some rivals, like the Moto G73, Redmi Note 12 5G, and the Realme 10 Pro. In storage-based benchmark tests, the phone showed the highest read and write speeds with the UFS 2.2 storage. The smartphone, however, maxes out at 128GB internal storage, which could be less for some users. Games like CoD: Mobile run on high graphics, and I didn't experience much lags or frame drops. The smartphone maxed out at 40FPS in Call of Duty: Mobile, with a stability of 97 per cent, according to Gamebench testing.

BATTERY

I was also able to get more than 5 hours of on-screen time easily. The battery optimisation during certain tasks like gaming, using GPS, watching content, or using the camera is very good. The smartphone has 44W fast charging if you use the charger inside the smartphone's box. We charged the iQOO Z7 5G from 0 to 100 using the smartphone's in-box charger, and it took just over 60 minutes.

CAMERA

The iQOO Z7 5G's primary camera captures good images. Wide images of a street or a garden capture colours accurately and the details are also sharp. On singular subjects, the phone's primary shooter adds a bit of a depth effect on its



own. The OIS makes it easier to focus on a subject, and the photos out of the iQOO Z7 5G's camera are quite nice for your basic social media posting. The images in low light are also pretty decent. However, in certain conditions, where the camera can not source much light from any source in a scene, the images in low light are grainy and lack sharpness. In portrait mode, the edge detection is nice and the background blur is also pretty good. However, sometimes, the edge smartphone gets confused and the edges aren't as smooth. Another thing I didn't like about its portrait mode is that the smartphone smoothen the subject's skin.

VERDICT

The iQOO Z7 5G is a pretty solid performer, showing some of the highest

benchmark numbers in its budget, with a slim and light form factor. The battery is small in size as compared to competition, but we get a decent battery backup with 44W fast charging that charges the device in a mere hour. We also get a pretty decent dual rear camera setup with OIS. The images out of this front camera are absolutely stunning, making the iQOO Z7 5G an easy smartphone to recommend for selfie lovers.

—Darab Mansoor Ali

SPECIFICATIONS

Chipset: MediaTek Dimensity 920 | GPU: Mali-G86 | OS: Funtouch OS 13 based on Android 13 | Display: 6.38-inch FHD+ AMOLED display | Display Refresh Rate: 90Hz | RAM: Up to 8GB | ROM: 128GB | Cameras (rear): 64MP + 2MP | Cameras (front): 16MP | Video: 4K @ 30fps | Battery: 4,500mAh | Charging: 44W

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